The Invisible Workers Behind AI: Data Labeling

A look at the human workers behind artificial intelligence systems

1 Data Labeling & AI Training

Humans label images, text, and videos for AI to learn from. These workers do anything from tagging objects in images, reviewing content, and even categorizing languages

2 Working Conditions

90% Of labeling is outsourced to workers in the Global South

Data labelers work as independent contractors with no benefits, job security, or minimum wage protections. 90% of labeling is outsourced to workers in the Global South—Kenya, India, Philippines, Venezuela. Workers report psychological trauma from labeling violent and disturbing content without mental health support. (The Verge, 2023)

25% Annual growth of an already $2.2 billion market

Tech giants like OpenAI, Google, Meta, and Amazon profit billions while outsourcing labeling to third-party companies like Sama and Scale AI. OpenAI's valuation reached $80 billion in 2024. The global data labeling market is worth $2.2 billion and growing 25% annually, yet workers see almost none of this value. (Forbes, 2024)

<$2 Per hour wages for AI Trainers in the Global South

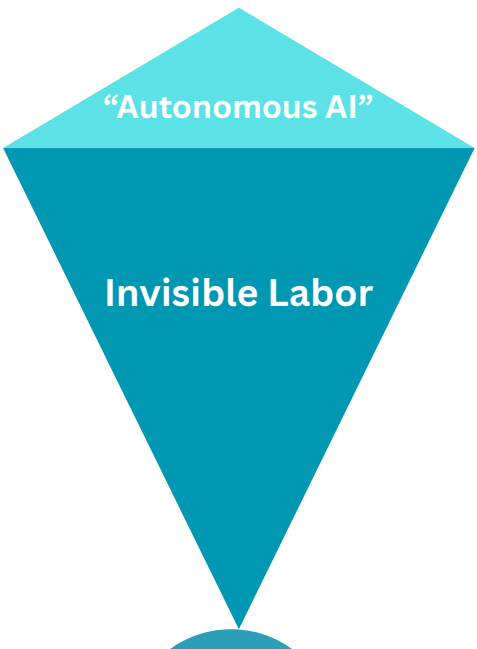
An estimated 15 million workers globally perform data labeling tasks, often earning less than $2 per hour. OpenAI paid Kenyan workers $1.32-$2/hour to label toxic content for ChatGPT's safety filters. (World Bank Data Work Report, 2023)

3 Who Really Profits?

Underpaid Workers → Data Labeled and AI Trained → AI Companies $$$$$$$$

Low paid global labor powers billion dollar AI Systems

4 Why Are Workers Hidden?



Workers are "Invisible" due to outsorced work, anonymous workers, and the idea that AI is "fully automated"

5 What Can We Do?

Demand Transparency : Asking AI companies to disclose their labor practices.

Support Fair Wages : Advocate for data workers to earn living wages with benefits

Human Recognition : Every time you use AI, remember who makes it possible

Question the Cost : Is "cheap" Artificial Inteligence worth the exploitation of humans?